

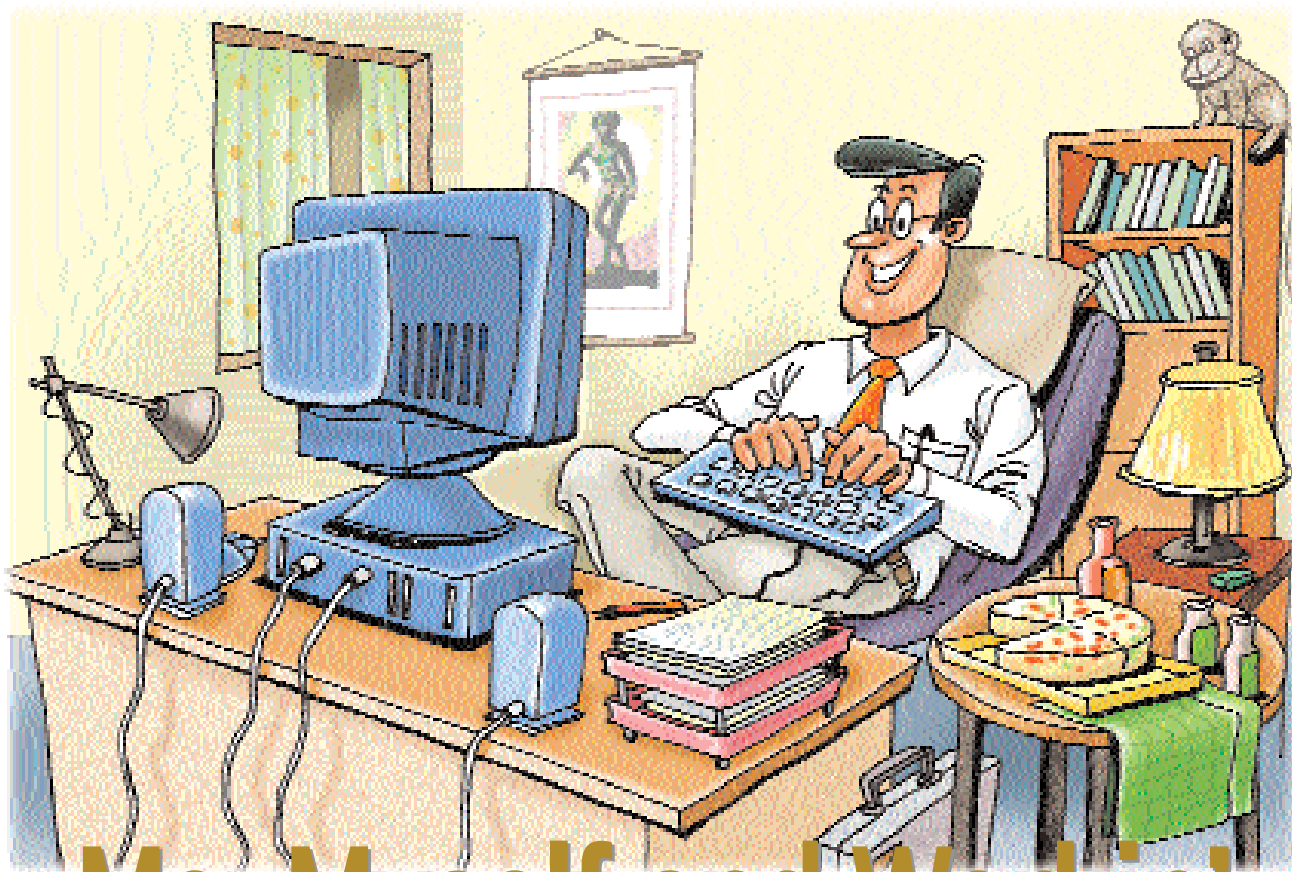


ILLUSTRATION: Mahesh Benkar

Me, Myself and Workin'

Long, hot hours of travelling, difficult work environments and slave drivers are all passé. Be your own boss, work in the comfort of your air-conditioned, music-filled room and make big bucks!

Do you want to break free of the corporate world, skip the coffee machine and step off the rumour mill to contribute to the economy on your own?

The latest trend of freelancing is more conducive to an independent worker. With cities growing in every direction, much of one's time is spent in commuting. Strict work routines, tyrannical management and the temptation of better opportunities around the corner have many of us thinking of a life of work at home.

The idea of working for yourself sounds sweet, but there are a lot of things to consider before you set out on your own. The primary one is whether your

work gives you that kind of freedom. Certain jobs, by their very nature require you to coordinate with a team. While the Internet has made communication easier, it does not do away with all the barriers. The IT and media industry, however, offers great scope of working from the confines of your home—copywriters, writers, network consultants and Web designers thrive professionally in their own habitat.

Players on the field

Amith Ellur, a certified Microsoft consultant, has been freelancing for various companies for the past six years. His work ranges from setting up a smooth workflow process to simple database opera-

tions. His work hours and fees depend upon the nature of work. The reason he chose to freelance, Ellur says is, "If you are an employee, people recognise the company you belong to and not the individual; if you are a freelancer, people recognise you and your work."

Chandan Naik, a layout artist, has another reason to be in the freelancing game. He lives in Borivili, a far-flung suburb of Mumbai, which makes his travelling time go up to anywhere between 2 and 3 hours in any direction to get to work. This is a large chunk of his waking hours, considering that his job would involve late nights. Moreover, his workload would usually avalanche during a certain time period, instead of being

// Freelancers are entrepreneurs by themselves, so they have to keep learning and updating their knowledge to provide quality solutions on time, everytime //

—Amith Ellur, Microsoft Consultant

